OpenAI Codex CLI: A Rust-Built Open-Source Coding Agent

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2026-05-02

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OpenAI Codex is an open-source CLI coding agent at version v0.128.0, available at github.com/openai/codex. Built primarily in Rust (96.3% of the codebase), it is licensed Apache 2.0 and has 443 contributors. Users can sign in with their ChatGPT account and access GPT-5.5 integration directly from the terminal. The tool is also available as an IDE extension and desktop app, making it accessible across different workflows.

The most significant addition is Symphony, an orchestration specification published on April 27, 2026. Symphony defines how multiple Codex instances coordinate on complex projects through task decomposition, agent-to-agent communication, shared context, and conflict resolution. This protocol could become the standard for multi-agent coding coordination, similar to how MCP became the standard for model-context integration.

The Apache 2.0 license is a deliberate strategic choice. It allows anyone to commercially fork Codex, which encourages adoption and makes the protocol layer (Symphony) more likely to become a shared standard. The Rust foundation gives the tool substantial performance advantages over Python and Node.js alternatives, with faster startup times and lower memory consumption. At 757 releases, the pace of iteration signals that OpenAI treats this as a core product rather than a side project. Between Codex and Claude Code, terminal-based coding agents have become a primary interface for professional software development.

Sources:

- Codex GitHub
- Codex Documentation
- OpenAI Codex IDE

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